

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART THREE · PEOPLE

CHAPTER 9 · GENRE

Genre is the promise a film makes before it starts. The shape comes after.

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

Thelma & Louise · 1991 · 130 min · dir. Ridley Scott · written by Callie Khouri · MGM

This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you press play" and resume after the credits.

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner. This is the last one.

*Two sets of outlaws running for the Mexican border. Both films make the same promise inside twenty minutes: this is a crime film, and somebody is going to pay for it. *Thelma & Louise* keeps that promise to the last frame.*

*From *Dusk Till Dawn* keeps it for about an hour, reaches Mexico, and then becomes a different film altogether, with no warning and no apology. One honours the contract. The other tears it up halfway through and never looks back. Harvey Keitel is in both.*

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

THELMA & LOUISE

1991 • 130 min • dir. Ridley Scott • written by Callie Khouri • MGM

Two friends leave for a weekend away from their small lives in Arkansas. One night at a roadside bar changes everything, and they keep driving.

Why it is on the ballot. It takes the oldest American genre promise — outlaws on the run — hands it to two women, and then keeps it with total conviction. It never cheats and never swerves, and it arrives exactly where its genre was always heading.

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

IT WAS A FIRST SCRIPT, AND IT WON THE OSCAR

Callie Khouri was working in music videos when she wrote it. It was her first screenplay, and it won Best Original Screenplay. The film took six nominations in five categories, with Susan Sarandon and Geena Davis both nominated for Best Actress, plus Ridley Scott for directing, Adrian Biddle for cinematography and Thom Noble for editing.

LOOK OUT FOR A YOUNG BRAD PITT

J.D. first went to William Baldwin, who dropped out. George Clooney, Christian Slater, Robert Downey Jr., Mark Ruffalo and Dermot Mulroney were among those who read for it. Geena Davis screen-tested with several of them and recommended Pitt.

THE WEST IS UTAH AND CALIFORNIA

The story runs through Arkansas and Oklahoma, but almost none of it was shot there. The road belongs to rural California, Utah and Colorado, and the red-rock country is the land above the Colorado River near Moab, Utah — not the Grand Canyon it is so often taken for.

WHILE YOU WATCH

Open each one only when you reach it.

BEFORE THEY LEAVE

The Polaroid

The two women take a snapshot of themselves before they set off.

Why it matters: It is who they were before the genre got hold of them. Keep that photo in mind all the way down the road.

THE PARKING LOT

The promise is made

About twenty minutes in, one moment turns a weekend comedy into a crime film.

Why it matters: This is the contract. From this second the film owes you an outlaw story, and everything that follows pays it.

LOUISE'S RULE

Not through Texas

Louise refuses the direct route to Mexico because it goes through Texas, and will not say why.

Why it matters: The genre is pulling them south and her past is pulling against it. The route becomes the character.

THE LAST SCENE

Tragedy or getaway?

Surrounded at the edge of a canyon, they make a choice, and the film freezes.

Why it matters: The freeze-frame and the fade to white hand the decision to you. Bring your answer on Sunday.

AFTER THE CREDITS

Everything here gives the film away. Keep it for afterwards.

OPEN

The ending had to be protected

A longer version was shot and exists on home video: the car falls, Hal walks to the wreck, the helicopter arrives. Scott also considered and rejected a version in which Louise pushes Thelma clear. Khouri has said Scott “really fought for that ending,” and his right to shoot it was written into his contract, because the studio kept asking for something else. Roger Ebert thought the fade to white honoured the tragedy and the credits montage took it back.

OPEN

Harvey Keitel plays the only man on their side

Detective Hal Slocumb is the one character trying to bring them in alive. Five years later Keitel turned up in *From Dusk Till Dawn* as a preacher driving his family toward Mexico.

OPEN

It became a national argument

Time put it on the cover on 24 June 1991 under the line “Why Thelma & Louise Strikes a Nerve.” Hans Zimmer scored it, with Pete Haycock’s slide guitar on the main theme.

01 Watch the last shot and decide: is it a tragedy, or a getaway?

02 At what point did you stop expecting them to turn back?

03 The film never changes genre. It just keeps going. Did that feel inevitable, or brave?

Where to watch

Find it here → [Thelma & Louise on JustWatch](#), which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

Sources: AFI Catalog · the Academy's awards database · Slate · Time · Movie-Locations

NOBODY CALLED IT NOIR

A FRENCH CRITIC NAMED SOMETHING HE SAW

After the Second World War, American films that had been kept out of occupied France arrived in Paris all at once: *The Maltese Falcon*, *Double Indemnity*, *Laura*, *Murder, My Sweet*. On 28 August 1946, in *L'Écran français*, the Italian-born critic Nino Frank wrote them up under the heading of a new kind of crime picture and called the mood *film noir*. The people who made those films in Hollywood had never heard the phrase. To them they were crime pictures.

AMERICANS MADE IT A GENRE

In the spring of 1972 the screenwriter Paul Schrader published "Notes on Film Noir" in *Film Comment*, and a generation of American directors started making noir deliberately: *Chinatown* (1974), *Body Heat* (1981), *Blade Runner* (1982). A label invented after the fact to describe a mood became a style you could aim at, with a checklist: hard shadows, voiceover, flashbacks, a doomed hero, a dangerous woman.

THAT IS HOW GENRE WORKS

Most genres are born this way. The films come first, the name comes later, and then the name becomes a promise to the audience. Once you know the name, you know what you have been promised: a western ends in a showdown, a romantic comedy ends together, a crime film makes somebody pay.

THREE THINGS A FILM CAN DO WITH THE PROMISE

ONE

KEEP IT

Deliver what the genre promised, as well as it can be delivered.

Die Hard · Heat · Thelma & Louise

TWO

BEND IT

Stay inside the genre while playing with what you expect.

Scream · Knives Out · Get Out

THREE

BREAK IT

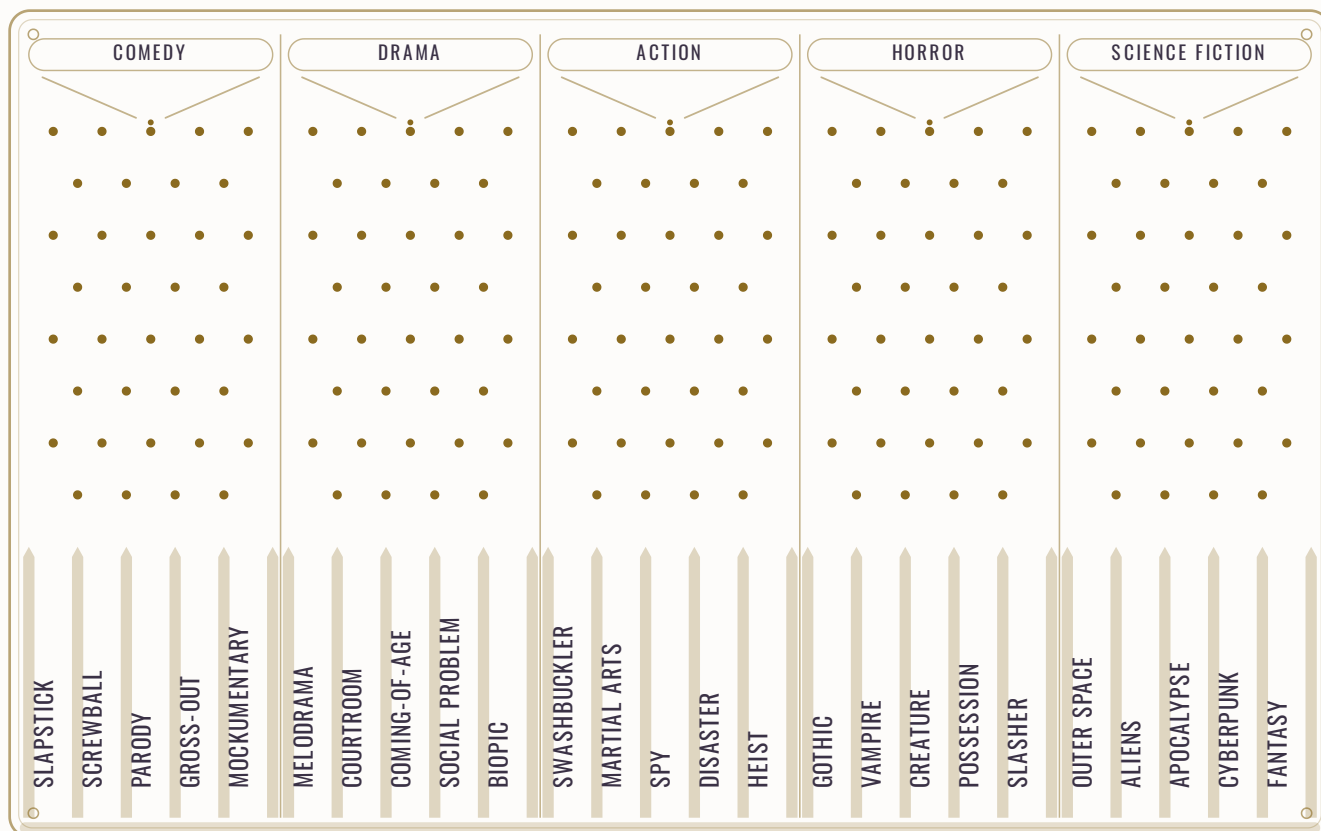
Switch genres partway through and dare you to follow.

Psycho · Audition · From Dusk Till Dawn

A genre is really a preset of everything in this book: a structure, a clock, a point of view, a frame, a cut, a sound, a kind of character and a kind of performance, all agreed before the lights go down.

WHERE A GENRE COMES FROM

Nobody sits down and invents a genre. The films turn up first, somebody notices they rhyme, and a name arrives afterwards — often from a critic, sometimes decades late. Then the name starts working backwards, and films get made to fit it. Which is why the machine below claims nothing about what came first. It takes the five most used genres, cuts each into five of the sub-genres you are most likely to meet, and drops a ball down each.



COMEDY

1. Slapstick

Bodies and objects rebel. The pratfall, the chase and the collision tell the joke, not the dialogue.

FIRST *L'Arroseur arrosé*, 1895 — forty-five seconds, and the first fiction film anyone made.

MOST WATCHED *Home Alone*, 1990 — \$477m.

2. Screwball

Two mismatched people insult each other into love, fast, and usually across a class line.

FIRST Disputed — *It Happened One Night* and *Twentieth Century*, both 1934. The word arrived in 1936.

MOST WATCHED *It Happened One Night*, 1934 — no gross survives; it swept all five top Oscars.

3. Parody

Copies one film, or one whole genre, closely enough to be recognised, and then punctures it.

FIRST Usually *The Little Train Robbery*, 1905 — children robbing a train two years after the real one. Thinly evidenced.

MOST WATCHED *Austin Powers in Goldmember*, 2002 — \$296m.

4. Gross-out

Aimed at the gag reflex. Bodily fluids, taboo and bad taste, all played for the laugh.

FIRST Disputed — *Pink Flamingos*, 1972, is the archetype; the press first used the phrase for *Animal House*, 1978.

MOST WATCHED *The Hangover*, 2009 — \$466m.

5. Mockumentary

Fiction shot and cut as a documentary, so that the form itself is the joke.

FIRST Disputed — *David Holzman's Diary*, 1967, or *Take the Money and Run*, 1969. *Spinal Tap*, 1984, only fixed it.

MOST WATCHED *Borat*, 2006 — \$262m.

DRAMA

1. Melodrama

Emotion at maximum. Virtue suffers, fate is cruel, and the score tells you exactly what to feel.

FIRST None — it walked in from the nineteenth-century stage already finished. Griffith set its film shape, *Way Down East*, 1920.

MOST WATCHED *Gone with the Wind*, 1939 — \$3.4bn adjusted, still the largest audience ever sold.

2. Courtroom

The story happens in one room, where talk is the action and a verdict is the clock.

FIRST Unsettled — *Falsely Accused!*, 1908, is the earliest title cited and barely documented. *The Passion of Joan of Arc*, 1928, is the earliest anyone screens.

MOST WATCHED *A Few Good Men*, 1992 — \$243m.

3. Coming-of-age

One summer, or one year, in which a young person crosses a line and cannot go back over it.

FIRST Nobody names one. *Zéro de conduite*, 1933, *Rebel Without a Cause*, 1955, and *The 400 Blows*, 1959, are all put forward.

MOST WATCHED *Grease*, 1978 — \$396m.

4. Social problem

Puts a named injustice on trial through one ordinary person who has to live inside it.

FIRST *Traffic in Souls*, 1913 — "melodrama, social indictment and documentary" at once, says the Library of Congress.

MOST WATCHED *Erin Brockovich*, 2000 — \$258m.

5. Biopic

One real life compressed into a shape: the rise, the cost, the moment they became the name.

FIRST *Jeanne d'Arc*, 1900, Méliès — eleven minutes, and the earliest film anyone files as a biopic.

MOST WATCHED *Michael*, 2026 — the first biopic past a billion.

ACTION

1. Swashbuckler

Sword-fighting adventure with a grinning hero who leaps, duels and rescues. Never grim.

FIRST *The Mark of Zorro*, 1920 — Douglas Fairbanks more or less wrote the job description.

MOST WATCHED *Pirates of the Caribbean: Dead Man's Chest*, 2006 — \$1.07bn.

2. Martial arts

The fights are the storytelling: trained bodies, choreography, and a code the hero has to earn.

FIRST *The Burning of the Red Lotus Temple*, 1928 — Shanghai, silent, and eighteen sequels.

MOST WATCHED *The Karate Kid*, 2010 — \$359m.

3. Spy

Cover identities and betrayal. The weapon is information, and nobody is who they say they are.

FIRST None settled — British shorts of 1913 and 1914 come first; Lang's *Spione*, 1928, set the moves still in use.

MOST WATCHED *Skyfall*, 2012 — \$1.11bn.

4. Disaster

A crowd of strangers against something overwhelming.

The question is who survives, not who did it.

FIRST *Deluge*, 1933 — lost for fifty years, and found again in 1981.

MOST WATCHED *Titanic*, 1997 — \$2.26bn.

5. Heist

A crew assembles, plans an impossible robbery in detail, does it, and then the plan comes apart.

FIRST Disputed — *The Asphalt Jungle*, 1950, or *Rififi*, 1955.

MOST WATCHED *Ocean's Eleven*, 2001 — \$451m.

HORROR

1. Gothic

Dread built out of place and inheritance: an old house, a family curse, and a building that seems to want something.

FIRST Disputed — *Le Manoir du diable*, 1896, has the furniture; gothic cinema proper is usually dated to *Caligari*, 1920, or *Nosferatu*, 1922.

MOST WATCHED *Bram Stoker's Dracula*, 1992 — \$216m. Gothic is a mood, not a box-office category.

2. Vampire

An undead predator who has to be invited in, feeds on blood, and turns attraction into something catching.

FIRST *Nosferatu*, 1922 — the earliest that survives. *Drakula halála*, 1921, came first, but the film is lost and nobody can say what was in it.

MOST WATCHED *Breaking Dawn – Part 2*, 2012 — \$868m.

3. Creature

One oversized animal or monster hunts people while the authorities stand around arguing about it.

FIRST Disputed — *The Lost World*, 1925, for stop motion; *King Kong*, 1933, for the template; *Godzilla*, 1954, for the man in the suit.

MOST WATCHED *Jurassic World*, 2015 — \$1.67bn. Keep it to the B-picture strand and it is *Jaws*, 1975 — \$495m.

4. Possession

A body is occupied by something intelligent and evil, and faith rather than force is the only weapon that works.

FIRST Not *The Exorcist* — possession films come before 1973. But it wrote the grammar every one since has used.

MOST WATCHED *The Exorcist*, 1973 — \$431m across its releases.

5. Slasher

A masked killer works through a group of young people one at a time, and one of them is left to face him.

FIRST Nobody agrees. *Psycho* and *Peeping Tom*, both 1960; *A Bay of Blood*, 1971; *Black Christmas*, 1974; *Halloween*, 1978, fixed the formula.

MOST WATCHED *Halloween*, 2018 — \$260m.

SCIENCE FICTION

1. Outer space

Getting off the Earth is the engine of the story, and the vacuum supplies the danger.

FIRST *Le Voyage dans la Lune*, 1902, Méliès — with his own earlier trick films laying a claim.

MOST WATCHED *Star Wars: The Force Awakens*, 2015 — \$2.07bn.

2. Aliens

Something not human makes contact, and the real subject is whether we answer with curiosity or a weapon.

FIRST *Le Voyage dans la Lune*, 1902 — the Selenites are the first aliens anybody filmed.

MOST WATCHED *Avatar*, 2009 — \$2.92bn.

3. Apocalypse

Civilisation has already fallen. The film is about what the survivors eat, build and turn into.

FIRST Unsettled — *Verdens Undergang*, 1916, for the fall itself; *Deluge*, 1933, and *Five*, 1951, for what comes after, though that claim is asserted more often than sourced.

MOST WATCHED *I Am Legend*, 2007 — \$586m.

4. Cyberpunk

A near future run by corporations, where bodies and minds can be hacked and the hero is a low-life specialist.

FIRST *Blade Runner*, 1982 — four years older than the word. *Metropolis*, 1927, is named as an ancestor, not an origin.

MOST WATCHED *The Matrix Reloaded*, 2003 — \$742m.

5. Fantasy

Magic, myth or another world running on its own rules, and nobody in the film asks for a scientific explanation.

FIRST No settled credit. Everyone points at Méliès's trick films — *Le Manoir du diable*, 1896, then *Cendrillon*, 1899.

MOST WATCHED *Ne Zha 2*, 2025 — \$2.22bn.

Twenty-five bins, every one of them a sub-genre on the chart the club works from — which is also why Fantasy is a bin inside Science Fiction rather than a lane of its own.

Where the first film is genuinely argued over the bin says so rather than picking a winner, which turns out to be most of them. The last two lanes are what Europe files together as **fantastic cinema**: horror, science fiction and fantasy as one family, the word Sitges has used since 1968 and the festivals federation took for its name. They arrive together too. Méliès was making all three between 1896 and 1902, and which of them came first is an argument about labels nobody had invented yet.

ONE PIECE OF VOCABULARY

A **genre switch** is a deliberate change of genre inside one film. It works when the first promise has been kept so well that the break feels like a betrayal, and then gives you something worth being betrayed for.

WHY THESE FILMS, AND WHY LAST

Chapter 1 was the shape of a story. This chapter is the promise made before the shape begins. So the season ends where it started, with the rules: two films, one that keeps them to the end and one that breaks them halfway through, and arrives anyway. Next time you are in a theatre, ask which one the film is doing.

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from the AFI Catalog, the BFI, the Library of Congress, the Academy's awards database, Dartmouth's film-genre guides, Box Office Mojo, The Numbers, Guinness World Records, Roger Ebert and Film Comment. Box-office figures are worldwide gross except where marked. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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